

KEY CONCEPTS

As proposed by Erik Erikson, psychosocial theory accounts for systematic change over the life span through five basic concepts: (a) stages of development, (b) psychosocial crises, (c) a radius of significant relationships, (d) prime adaptive ego qualities, and (e) core pathologies.

Stages of Development

A **developmental stage** is a period of life that is characterized by a specific underlying organization. At every stage, some characteristics differentiate it from the preceding and succeeding stages. Stage theories propose a specific direction for development. At each stage, the accomplishments from the previous stages provide resources for mastering the new challenges. Each stage is unique and leads to the acquisition of new skills related to new capabilities (Davison, King, Kitchener, & Parker, 1980; Flavell, 1982; Levin, 1986). Within the framework of psychosocial theory the concept of stages of development refers to patterns of changes in self-concept and a coordinated sense of self in society based on new cognitive capacities, new learning, and new relationship skills. At each stage, the biological, psychological, and societal systems converge around a set of defining challenges that require a new view of the self in society and a new way of relating to others (Whitbourne, Sneed, & Sayer, 2009; Newman and Newman, 2015).

Erikson (1950/1963) proposed that the stages of development follow the **epigenetic principle**, a biological plan for growth that allows each function to emerge systematically until the fully functioning organism has developed. An assumption of this and other stage theories is that the stages form a sequence. Although one can anticipate challenges that will occur at a later stage, one passes through the stages in an orderly pattern of growth. In the logic of psychosocial theory, the entire life span is required for all the functions of psychosocial development to appear and become integrated. There is no going back to an earlier stage because experience makes retreat impossible. In contrast to other stage theories, however, Erikson suggested that one can review and reinterpret previous stages in the light of new insight and/or new experiences. In addition, the themes of earlier stages may reemerge at any point, bringing a new meaning or a new resolution to an earlier conflict. Joan Erikson reflects on the fluidity and hopefulness in this perspective:

This sequential growth . . . is now known to be more influenced by the social milieu than was in previous years considered possible . . . Where a strength is not adequately developed according to the given sequence for its scheduled period of critical resolution, the supports of the environment may bring it into appropriate balance at a later period. Hope remains constant throughout life that more sturdy resolutions of the basic confrontation may be realized. (Erikson, 1988, pp. 74–75)

Erikson (1950/1963) proposed eight stages of psychosocial development. The conception of these stages can be traced in part to the stages of psychosexual development proposed by Freud and in part to Erikson's own observations and rich mode of thinking.

Figure 8.1 is the chart Erikson produced in *Childhood and society* to describe the stages of psychosocial development. The diagonal boxes identify the main psychosocial ego conflicts of each stage. These ego conflicts produce new ego skills. In Erikson's original model, you will note that the periods of life are given names, such as *oral-sensory* or *puberty and adolescence*, but no ages. This approach reflected Erikson's emphasis on an individual timetable for development, guided by both biological maturation and cultural expectations.

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
1. Oral-sensory	Basic trust vs. Mistrust							
2. Muscular-anal		Autonomy vs. Shame, doubt						
3. Locomotor-genital			Initiative vs. Guilt					
4. Latency				Industry vs. Inferiority				
5. Puberty and adolescence					Identity vs. Role confusion			
6. Young adulthood						Intimacy vs. Isolation		
7. Adulthood							Generativity vs. Stagnation	
8. Maturity								Ego integrity vs. Despair

Figure 8.1 Erikson’s Model of the Psychosocial Stages of Development

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The concept of life stages permits us to consider the various aspects of development such as physical growth, social relationships, and cognitive capacities at a given period of life and to speculate about their interrelation. It also encourages a focus on the experiences that are unique to each life period—experiences that deserve to be understood both in their own right and for their contribution to subsequent development.

One must avoid thinking of stages as pigeonholes. Just because a person is described as being at a given stage does not mean that he or she cannot function at other levels. It is not unusual for people to anticipate later challenges before they become dominant. Many children of toddler (muscular-anal) and preschool (locomotor-genital) age, for example, play house, envisioning having a husband or a wife and children. You might say that, in this play, they are anticipating the issues of intimacy and generativity that lie ahead. The experience of having a child, whether this occurs at age 18, 25, or 35, is likely to raise issues of generativity, even if the theory suggests that this theme is not in its peak ascendancy until middle adulthood (McAdams & de St. Aubin, 1998). While some elements of each psychosocial theme can be observed at all ages, the intensity with which they are expressed at certain times marks their importance in the definition of a developmental stage. Erikson, Erikson, and Kivnick (1986) put it this way:

The epigenetic chart also rightly suggests that the individual is never struggling only with the tension that is focal at the time. Rather, at every successive developmental stage, the individual

is also increasingly engaged in the anticipation of tensions that have yet to become focal and in reexperiencing those tensions that were inadequately integrated when they were focal; similarly engaged are those whose age-appropriate integration was then, but is no longer, adequate. (p. 39)

As one leaves a stage, the achievements of that period are neither lost nor irrelevant to later stages. Although the theory suggests that important ego strengths emerge from the successful resolution of conflicts at every stage, one should not assume that these strengths, once established, are never challenged or shaken. Events may take place later in life that call into question the essential beliefs established in an earlier period.

For example, the psychosocial conflict during early school age (locomotor-genital stage) is initiative versus guilt. Its positive outcome, a sense of initiative, is a joy in innovation and experimentation and a willingness to take risks in order to learn more about the world. Once achieved, the sense of initiative provides a positive platform for the formation of social relationships as well as for further creative intellectual inquiry and discovery. However, experiences in a highly authoritarian school environment or in a very judgmental, shaming personal relationship may cause one to inhibit this sense of initiative or to mask it with a facade of indifference.

The idea of life stages highlights the changing orientations toward one's self and others that dominate periods of the life span. Movement from one stage to the next is the result of changes in several major systems at approximately the same time. The new mixture of needs, capabilities, and expectations is what produces the new orientation toward experience at each stage.

Psychosocial Crisis

A **psychosocial crisis** refers to a state of tension that results from the discrepancies between the person's competences at the beginning of a stage and the society's expectations for behavior at that period of life (Erikson, 1950/1963). The psychosocial crisis arises because one must make psychological efforts to adjust to the demands of the social environment at each stage of development (Erikson, 1950/1963). The word *crisis* in this context refers to a normal set of stresses and strains rather than to an extraordinary set of events. Societal demands vary from stage to stage. People experience these demands as mild but persistent expectations for behavior. They may be demands for greater self-control, further development of skills, or a stronger commitment to goals. Before the end of each stage of development, the individual tries to achieve a resolution, to adjust to society's demands, and at the same time to translate those demands into personal terms. This process produces a state of tension that the individual must reduce in order to proceed to the next stage.

Psychosocial Crises of the Life Stages. Figure 8.1 lists the psychosocial crisis at each stage of development from infancy (oral-sensory) through later adulthood (maturity). This scheme, derived from Erikson's model, expresses the crises as polarities—for example, trust versus mistrust, and autonomy versus shame and doubt. These contrasting conditions suggest the underlying dimensions along which each psychosocial crisis is resolved. According to psychosocial theory, most people experience both positive and negative ends of the continuum. The inevitable discrepancy between one's level of development at the beginning of a stage and society's push for a new level of functioning by the end of it creates at least a mild degree of the negative condition. Even within a loving, caring family environment that promotes trust, an infant will experience

some moments of frustration or disappointment that result in mistrust. The outcome of the crisis at each stage is a balance or integration of the two opposing forces. For each person, the relative frequency and significance of positive and negative experiences will contribute to a resolution of the crisis that lies along a continuum from extremely positive to extremely negative.

The likelihood of a completely positive or a completely negative resolution is small. Most individuals resolve the crises in a generally positive direction, supported by a combination of positive experiences combined with natural maturational tendencies. At each successive stage, however, the likelihood of a negative resolution increases as societal demands become more complex and the chances of encountering societal barriers to development increase. A positive resolution of each crisis provides new ego strengths that help the person meet the demands of the next stage. A negative resolution contributes to withdrawal and rigidity that make it more difficult to meet the new demands of the next stage.

To understand the process of growth at each life stage, we have to consider the negative as well as the positive pole of each crisis. The dynamic tension between the positive and negative forces respects and reflects the struggles we all encounter to restrain unbridled impulses, to overcome fears and doubts, and to look past our own needs to consider the needs of others. The negative poles offer insight into basic areas of human vulnerability. Experienced in moderation, the negative forces result in a clarification of ego positions, individuation, and moral integrity. While a steady diet of mistrust is undesirable, for example, it is important that a trusting person be able to evaluate situations and people for their trustworthiness and to discern cues about safety or danger in any encounter. In every psychosocial crisis, experiences at both the positive and the negative poles contribute to the total range of a person's adaptive capacities.

The term *crisis* implies that normal development does not proceed smoothly. The theory hypothesizes that tension and conflict are necessary to the developmental process. Crisis and its resolution are basic, biologically based components of life experience at every stage. In fact, they are what drives the ego system to develop new capacities.

The term *psychosocial* draws attention to the fact that the psychosocial crises are, in part, the result of cultural pressures and expectations. As part of normal development, individuals will experience tension because of the culture's need to socialize and integrate its members. The concept acknowledges the dynamic conflicts between individuality and group membership at each period of life.

The exact nature of the conflict is not the same at each stage. For example, few cultural limits are placed on infants. The outcome of the infancy stage depends greatly on the skill of the caregiver. At early school age, the culture stands in fairly direct opposition to the child's initiative in some matters by discouraging curiosity or questioning about certain topics, and offers abundant encouragement to a child's initiative in others. In young adulthood, the dominant cultural push is toward the establishment of intimate relationships; yet an individual may be unable to attain intimacy because of the lack of time to cultivate intimate relationships, competing pressures from the workplace, cultural norms against certain expressions of intimacy, or restrictions against certain types of unions.

As reflected in the epigenetic principle, the succession of crises occurs in a predictable sequence over the life course. Although Erikson did not specify the exact ages for each crisis, the theory hypothesizes an age-related progression in which each crisis has its time of special ascendancy. The combination of biological, psychological, and societal forces that operate to bring about change has a degree of regularity within society that places each psychosocial crisis at a particular period of life.

Radius of Significant Relationships

The third organizing principle of psychosocial theory is the **radius of significant relationships** (Erikson, 1982, p. 31). These relationships are thought to be the vehicle or channel through which age-related cultural and community expectations are communicated. A person's ego includes a social processing system that is sensitive to social expectations. Initially, a person focuses on a small number of relationships, beginning with the primary caregivers, siblings, and other close family members. During childhood, adolescence, and early adulthood, the number of relationships expands and the quality of these relationships takes on greater variety in depth and in intensity. In later adulthood, the person often returns to a smaller number of extremely important relationships that provide opportunities for great depth and intimacy.

At each stage of life, this network of relationships determines the demands that will be made on the person, the way he or she will be taken care of, and the meaning that the person will derive from the relationships. The relationship network varies from person to person, but each person has a network of significant relationships and an increasing readiness to enter into more complex social life (Vanzetti & Duck, 1996). The quality of these relationships and the norms for interaction influence the way the psychosocial crisis of the stage is experienced, and the interpersonal context in which it is resolved.

Prime Adaptive Ego Qualities

According to psychosocial theory, at each stage of life, consistent efforts to face and cope with the psychosocial crisis of the period result in the formation of basic adaptive capacities referred to as the **prime adaptive ego qualities**. When coping is unsuccessful and the challenges of the period are not adequately mastered, individuals are likely to form maladaptive orientations, referred to as the **core pathologies**.

Erikson (1978) postulated prime adaptive ego qualities that develop from the positive resolution of the psychosocial crisis of a given stage and provide resources for coping with the next. Drawing upon his concept of an epigenetic principle, Erikson viewed the prime adaptive ego qualities as guided by evolution and embedded into the developmental blueprint for human maturation. "Without them, and their re-emergence from generation to generation, all other and more changeable systems of human values lose their spirit and their relevance" (Erikson, 1950/1963, p. 274).

When the psychosocial crisis is resolved with a favorable balance between the positive and the negative poles, an enduring strength emerges. Erikson described these qualities as mental states that form a basic orientation toward the interpretation of life experiences. A sense of competence, for example, permits a person to feel free to exercise his or her wits to solve problems without being weighed down by a sense of inferiority.

The prime adaptive ego qualities and their definitions are: (a) infancy–hope, which is an enduring belief that one can attain one's deep and essential wishes; (b) toddlerhood–will, which is a determination to exercise free choice and self-control; (c) early school age–purpose, which is the courage to imagine and pursue valued goals; (d) middle childhood–competence, which is the free exercise of skill and intelligence in the completion of tasks; (e) early adolescence–fidelity to others, which is the ability freely to pledge and sustain loyalty to others; (f) later adolescence–fidelity to values, which is the ability freely to pledge and sustain loyalty to values and ideologies; (g) early adulthood–love, which is a capacity for mutuality that transcends childhood dependency; (h) middle adulthood–care, which is a commitment to concern about what has

been generated; and (i) later adulthood–wisdom, which is a detached yet active concern with life itself in the face of death.

These ego qualities contribute to the person's dominant worldview, which is continuously reformulated to accommodate new ego qualities. The importance of many of the prime adaptive ego qualities has been verified by research. For example, hope has been identified as a significant factor in allowing people to cope with adversity as well as to organize their actions to achieve difficult goals (Snyder, 1994). People with a hopeful attitude have a better chance of maintaining their spirits and strength in the face of crisis than people who are pessimistic. In interviews with people in very old age, Erikson and his colleagues found that those who were hopeful about their own future as well as that of their children were more intellectually vigorous and psychologically resilient than those not characterized by this orientation (Erikson et al., 1986).

Core Pathologies

Although most people develop the prime adaptive ego qualities, a potential core pathology or destructive force may also develop as a result of ineffective, negatively balanced crisis resolution at each stage (Erikson, 1982). The core pathologies and their definitions are: (a) infancy–withdrawal, social and emotional detachment; (b) toddlerhood–compulsion, repetitive behaviors motivated by impulse or by restrictions against the expression of impulse; (c) early school age–inhibition, a psychological restraint that prevents freedom of thought, expression, and activity; (d) middle childhood–inertia, a paralysis of action and thought that prevents productive work; (e) early adolescence–dissociation, an inability to connect with others; (f) later adolescence–repudiation, rejection of most roles and values because they are viewed as alien to oneself; (g) early adulthood–exclusivity, an elitist shutting out of others; (h) middle adulthood–rejection, unwillingness to include certain others or groups of others in one's generative concern; and (i) later adulthood–disdain, a feeling of scorn for the weakness and frailty of oneself and others.

The core pathologies also serve as guiding orientations for behavior. These pathologies move people away from others, tend to prevent further exploration of interpersonal relations, and obstruct the resolution of subsequent psychosocial crises. The energy that would normally be directed toward mastering the developmental tasks of a stage is directed instead toward resisting or avoiding change. The core pathologies are not simply passive limitations or barriers to growth. They are energized worldviews leading to strategies that protect people from further unwanted association with the social system and its persistent, tension-producing demands. Figure 8.2 illustrates the mechanism for positive and negative psychosocial development at each stage.